Copperline Community League Rulebook

This rulebook sets out how matches in the Copperline Community League are played during the 2026 autumn season. It applies to both divisions, premier and championship, and to every registered club. Captains are responsible for making sure their players know it. Questions about interpretation go to the league office, which answers captains Monday to Thursday, 18:00 to 21:00.

Match length

Every league match is played as two halves of 40 minutes, a total of 80 minutes of normal play. There is a half-time interval of up to 10 minutes. The referee adds stoppage time at the end of each half for injuries, substitutions that took unusually long, and clear time-wasting. The referee's watch is the official clock. A match that is abandoned before the 60th minute is replayed; a match abandoned after the 60th minute stands at the score when play stopped unless the league office decides otherwise.

Squad size and substitutions

A matchday squad is at most 16 players. Eleven players start the match and up to five are named as substitutes. Substitutions are rolling: a player who has been substituted off may come back on later in the same match. A substitution is made at a stoppage in play, with the referee's permission and with the outgoing player leaving at the nearest touchline. Each team must have a goalkeeper on the pitch at all times. If a team cannot name five substitutes, it may play with fewer, but the squad can never exceed 16.

Team size and minimum players

Teams play 11 against 11. A match may start with as few as 8 players per side if both captains agree and tell the referee before kick-off. If a team has fewer than 7 players on the pitch at any point, the referee abandons the match and the team with the shortfall forfeits. The forfeit procedure is described in the fixtures and postponement policy.

Kit and equipment

Each club has a home kit and an away kit with clearly different colours. When kits clash, the away team changes. Players must wear shin guards under their socks. Studs must be moulded or bladed boots suitable for the pitch surface; metal studs are not permitted on the 3G artificial pitch at Harbour Park. Jewellery must be removed or covered. Goalkeepers wear a top that differs from both teams and the officials. The match ball is a size 5 ball supplied by the home club, and the referee checks it before kick-off.

Scoring and points

A goal is scored when the whole ball crosses the line between the posts and under the crossbar, provided no rule has been broken. The team that scores more goals wins. League points are awarded as follows: 3 points for a win, 1 point for a draw and 0 points for a loss. League tables are ordered by points. If clubs are level on points, the order is decided by goal difference, then by goals scored, then by the result of the match between the clubs involved.

Kick-off and local time

Kick-off times are set in local time and published on the fixtures list. A team that is not ready to play within 10 minutes of the published kick-off may be reported by the referee. The league office publishes the table after each round of matches, normally by the following Monday.

Conduct on the pitch

Players must accept the referee's decisions without argument. Only the captain may speak to the referee about a

decision, calmly and at a stoppage. Cards, bans and appeals are covered in the discipline code, and general behaviour for players, coaches and spectators is covered in the code of conduct. The referee's report is the official record of the match.

Changes to the rules

The league committee may change this rulebook between seasons or, in an emergency, during the season. Any change is published to all captains at least seven days before it takes effect, except for urgent safety changes, which take effect immediately.